Country Profile: Guinea

Nation-Building Policies Dataset

- Number of groups in country: 6
- Plurality religion: Islam
- Official language: French (1990–2020)
- Official religion: None
- Core group: None

Historical Background

In 1849 the French established a protectorate in the territory of modern Guinea. In 1958 Guinea became the first French colony to gain independence. Its contemporary history has been marked by periods of political instability such as numerous military coups, the most recent occurring in 2021.

Groups

The NBP Dataset identifies six primarily ethnolinguistic ethnic groups in Guinea. In most instances, the group's name corresponds directly with the name of its language. [1] The population of Guinea is predominantly Muslim, and religious divisions are not a significant factor in the country. The NBP utilizes data from the Ethnic Power Relations (EPR) project and the All Minorities at Risk (AMAR) database to estimate the sizes of groups in Guinea, resulting in a combined total of 103%.[2] To address this discrepancy, the NBP adjusts the figures by reducing the population sizes of the three largest groups—the Fulani, Malinke, and Susu—by 1% each.

There is no core group in Guinea. Following the 1984 military coup and the post-1986 consolidation of power by the new president Lansana Conté, a Susu, his ethnic group became favored in major government, military, and public posts until his death in 2008. However, despite this period of Susu political dominance, their

[1] Ethnologue, 2024.
[2] EPR, 2021; AMAR, 2016.

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influence did not translate into Guinea's state identity reflecting or prioritizing the Susu identity.[3]

- **Fulani** in Guinea, also known as Peuhl, are mainly associated with the Pular language. They are the largest group in the country at 39% and are concentrated in the Fouta Djallon mountain plateau in the western interior.
- **Malinke** speak a variety of languages classified under the Manding node of the Mande language cluster. In Guinea, 90% of the group is associated with Eastern Maninkakan as well as Sankaran Maninka and Konyanka, spoken by 4% and 6% of the group, respectively. According to Ethnologue, Eastern Maninkakan is also the de facto language of Guinea's national identity. [4] Its speakers are the second largest group in Guinea at 29%. Malinke predominate in the Niger plains of the northeast, close to the border with neighboring Mali.
- **Susu** speak the Susu language. They are the third largest group in Guinea at 19% and mainly reside on the coast. They are a predominant group in the capital, Conakry, as well.

Several smaller ethnolinguistic groups are concentrated in the forest highlands in the south-east of Guinea.

- **Guerze** are associated with a language called Guinean Kpelle. They make up around 4% of the population.
- **Kissi** speak the Kissi language and represent 7% of the population.
- **Toma** is associated with the Toma language. They constitute around 2% of the population. All three groups are religiously diverse, with segments practicing Christianity and Islam, while a significant portion continues to follow their traditional religions.

[3] EPR Atlas, 2024.
[4] Ethnologue, 2024.

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State Profile

Official Languages

The first two constitutions of Guinea, from 1958 and 1982, do not mention an official language. However, in the subsequent constitutions of 1990, 2010, and 2020, French is recognized as the official language of the state.

Official Religion

Regarding religion, all constitutions, except the 1982 Constitution—which makes no reference to religion—define the country as a secular state.

Education Policies

Since independence in 1958, Guinea's education policy has prioritized mass education as part of the "socialist cultural revolution". Under Sékou Touré, compulsory, free education for children aged 7 to 15 was established. To ensure universal access to education, private schools were nationalized in 1961. Private education was re-established in 1987.[5] In 1968, Touré also introduced a policy of Africanization, reforming the curriculum to emphasize national languages in elementary education.[6] After Touré's death in 1984 and the subsequent coup d'état, these policies were revised.[7] Guinea's current education policy is defined by the 1997 Education Law and a corresponding decree issued the same year.[8] However, due to the unavailability of these documents, NBP relies on secondary sources for information.

Language Education Policies

In 1968, French, which had been the language of instruction in schools since independence, was replaced by the "dominant" national language in each region for the first eight grades of public schools. To achieve this, the government designated eight languages as national languages: **Malinke**, **Susu**, **Pular**, **Kissi**, **Toma**, and **Kpelle**, as well as Bassari and Koniagi (also known as Wamey), which NBP does not include. National languages were also taught in language classes at the university level. This policy ended in 1984, when French once again became the language of

[5] UNESCO,1971.
[6] UNESCO, 1971; L'Aménagement linguistique dans le monde, 2024.
[7] Ibid.
[8] Loi d'orientation de l'Éducation Nationale n° L/97/022/AN; Le décret n° 97/196/PRG/SGG.

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instruction in public schools throughout the country. National languages continued to be taught in public schools, but only in optional language classes.[9]

Religious Education Policies

Since independence, Guinea has been defined as a secular state. Public schools have not offered classes in any religion or sectarian denomination. However, there are no restrictions on offering such classes in private schools.

Demographic Engineering and Violence

State-Based Violence

Under Sekou Touré (1958-1984), Guinea became an increasingly authoritarian state. The government employed political repression against perceived enemies, including intellectuals, merchants, public and civil service employees, the military, and eventually the Fulani ethnic group, which was accused of collaborating in a coup d'état plot. During the most repressive period (1970–1977), the president issued statements specifically targeting the Fulani. However, since no official policy was issued and exact numbers of Fulani victims are unavailable, NBP does not list these events as state-based violence against the Fulani.[10]

Constitutions and Laws

Between its independence in 1958 and 2020, Guinea was governed by five different constitutions.

The 1958 independence constitution omits any reference to ethnic groups and does not designate an official language. Article 1 declares Guinea a secular state, while the preamble forbids distinctions based on religion, though it does not explicitly address religious liberty.

The 1982 constitution similarly lacks any mention of specific groups or an official language. It also does not include references to religious liberty, the separation of church and state, or an official religion.

The 1990 constitution does not reference any particular group. Article 1 designates French as the official language of the Guinean state and establishes the country as

[9] L'Aménagement linguistique dans le monde, 2024.
[10] Arieff and McGovern, 2013; Human Rights Watch, 2011; Minority Rights, 2018; Pauthier, 2013.

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a secular state. Although religious liberty is not explicitly stated, the preamble prohibits religious distinctions.

The 2010 constitution does not refer to any specific group. Article 1 recognizes French as the official language and declares the country a secular state. Furthermore, Article 7 explicitly acknowledges universal freedom of religion.

The 2020 constitution does not specifically mention any groups. Article 1 defines French as the official language and Guinea as a secular state. Article 11 universally recognizes freedom of religion for the people of Guinea.

Citizenship Laws

Until 1983, birthright citizenship did not exist in Guinea, as outlined by the 1960 Nationality Law.[11] This changed with the 1983 Guinean Civil Code, currently in force, which allows individuals born in Guinea to foreign parents to acquire Guinean nationality upon reaching the age of majority, provided they have resided in Guinea since the age of 16.[12]

National Anthem(s)

The national anthem of Guinea has been in force since 1958. It is called "Liberté" and is written in French. It makes references to ancestors, past heroic deeds, martyrdom, and the military.[13]

[11] Ordonnance No.011 du 1 mars 1960 portant code de la nationalité Guinéenne.
[12] Loi 004/APN/83 du 16 février 1983 portant Code civil de Guinée; Manby, 2018.
[13] Nationalanthems.info, 2023.

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